

The Morning Briefing

VOL. 1, NO. 209
SAN ANTONIO, TEXAS

SATURDAY
AUGUST 15, 2026

PREPARED FOR MARCUS JOHNSON | US POLITICS · JUDICIARY · ISRAEL/MIDEAST · VATICAN · WORLD · LONG READS

LEAD STORY — ISRAEL / MIDDLE EAST

Trump Says He Will Declare Strait of Hormuz "U.S. Territory"; Iran Rejects Claim as Void

At a New York rally Friday, Trump said that once Iran is "finished being defeated" he will "pretty soon" declare the Strait of Hormuz — jointly held by Iran and Oman under international law — a US territory. A White House official later called it a joke. Iran's deputy foreign minister called the claim impossible to enforce "by tweet... nor by an election speech" and vowed to keep blockading the strait. Full analysis inside.

US POLITICS

Graham, Norman Head to Aug. 25 Runoff for Late Senator's Seat

Sen. Darline Graham took 32.7% (109,582 votes) and Rep. Ralph Norman took 24.6% (82,523 votes) in the Aug. 11 special primary to permanently fill the seat left vacant by Lindsey Graham's death on July 11. Ten Republicans ran; none reached a majority. President Trump endorsed Darline Graham, who was appointed to the seat and is running as a continuity candidate carrying her brother's platform. The Aug. 25 runoff winner faces Democrat Annie Andrews on Nov. 3.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is a live test of whether a Trump endorsement can settle a fractious primary field two-plus months before a midterm Republicans are favored to hold but cannot afford to bleed turnout in.

Washington Post [washingtonpost.com/politics/2026/08/11/south-carolina-senate-primary-lindsey-graham/](https://www.washingtonpost.com/politics/2026/08/11/south-carolina-senate-primary-lindsey-graham/) · **NPR** [npr.org/2026/08/11/nx-s1-5928375](https://www.npr.org/2026/08/11/nx-s1-5928375)

Scalise Won't Challenge Johnson for Speaker — If GOP Keeps House

House Majority Leader Steve Scalise says he won't run against Speaker Mike Johnson if Republicans hold their majority, calling Johnson's tenure "a great job" he has "earned." Asked three separate times whether he'd run for minority leader if Democrats flip the House, Scalise declined to answer.

WHY IT MATTERS

The hedge is itself the story — leadership succession jockeying is already underway inside the GOP conference ahead of a midterm many rate as close.

Political Wire politicalwire.com/2026/08/14/what-will-scalise-do-if-republicans-lose/

SCOTUS & THE JUDICIARY

Trump Asks Supreme Court to Save Ballroom Project From Injunction

The Trump administration asked the Supreme Court on Aug. 14 to block a D.C. Circuit injunction, effective Aug. 21, halting further construction of Trump's \$400 million, 90,000-square-foot White House ballroom on the site of the demolished East Wing. Judges Patricia Millett and Bradley Garcia ruled that Congress, not the president, holds "exclusive authority to regulate the construction and demolition of White House structures." The National Trust for Historic Preservation sued in December 2025, arguing the administration bypassed the National Capital Planning Commission, the Commission of Fine Arts, and Congress before demolition began.

ANALYTICAL READ

A clean test of unitary-executive theory against a concrete fact pattern — a torn-down wing of the people's house, built without the process Congress set up for exactly this. How the Court handles the emergency application signals how far it will let the removal-power line of cases run into control over physical federal property.

CBS News [cbsnews.com/news/trump-supreme-court-white-house-ballroom/](https://www.cbsnews.com/news/trump-supreme-court-white-house-ballroom/) · **SCOTUSblog** [scotusblog.com/2026/08/trump-brings-ballroom-dispute-to-the-supreme-court/](https://www.scotusblog.com/2026/08/trump-brings-ballroom-dispute-to-the-supreme-court/)

Court-Expansion Fight Still Simmering

Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries says "all options are on the table" on expanding the Supreme Court; Sen. Sheldon Whitehouse has instead centered an 18-year staggered-term-limits bill. Senate Judiciary Republicans, led by Chuck Grassley, are framing any expansion push as a revival of FDR-era court-packing.

WHY IT MATTERS

Neither party has the votes to move either plan now, but the rhetoric is midterm positioning for a Court whose approval rating has been sliding.

Senate Judiciary GOP judiciary.senate.gov/press/rep/releases/grassley-sounds-the-alarm

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

Trump's Hormuz "Territory" Claim, and Iran's Blunt Rejection

Speaking at a New York rally on Aug. 14, Trump said that once Iran is "finished being defeated," he will "pretty soon" declare the Strait of Hormuz — a waterway whose jurisdiction is shared by Iran and Oman under international law — a "territory of the United States." A White House official later told reporters he was joking. Iran's deputy foreign minister, Kazem Gharibabadi, rejected the claim: "The Strait of Hormuz cannot be taken over by a tweet, nor by an aircraft carrier, nor by issuing a decree, nor by an election speech," adding it "has been Iranian, is Iranian, and will remain Iranian," and that Iran will keep enforcing its blockade until the US "accepts the reality of defeat."

ANALYTICAL READ

A claim to annex a strait neither the US nor Israel has ever held sovereign title to is legally void on its face, and the swift unnamed-official walkback ("he was joking") suggests the White House itself understood how reckless the statement read. A prolonged standoff raises global oil and gas prices and hands hawks in both Washington and Jerusalem a durable rationale for keeping pressure on Tehran open-ended; the costs land on Gulf shippers and ordinary consumers, not on the parties escalating the rhetoric. Worth flagging: outlets covering this war, including Gulf and regional press, now routinely label it the "US-Israel war on Iran" — a framing choice, not a neutral description, that puts Israel's stake in this conflict squarely in view.

Al Jazeera aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/14/trump-says-he-will-declare-strait-of-hormuz-a-us-territory · **CNBC** cnbc.com/2026/08/15/iran-rebuffs-trumps-claim-over-hormuz

Settlers Besiege Palestinian Homes in Qusra; Netanyahu Silent

In Qusra, a West Bank village south of Nablus, Israeli settlers have besieged three Palestinian households since Sunday, cutting water and electricity and blocking residents from entering or leaving. US concern escalated after officials learned one targeted home belongs to a Palestinian American. Netanyahu has not personally commented; a government spokesperson called the conduct "deplorable" and "unacceptable" and promised arrests. US Ambassador Mike Huckabee went further, calling the besieging settlers "Israeli terrorists." France separately condemned the siege. The episode lands roughly two months before an Israeli election in which settler voters anchor part of Netanyahu's coalition.

ANALYTICAL READ

Treat the government's "deplorable/unacceptable" line skeptically — it surfaced only after sustained US pressure and only once a Palestinian-American victim raised Washington's stakes, not as a proactive response to a days-long siege. Netanyahu's own silence, given the election calendar, is the more informative data point. This fits a recurring pattern — settler impunity, condemnation only under outside pressure — that looks less like an ally managing a rogue fringe and more like how a state tolerates an irregular force it relies on politically. Huckabee's unusually blunt language from a normally reliably pro-Israel ambassador is itself a signal of Washington's alarm.

Al Jazeera aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/14/israeli-forces-block-activists-from-reaching-besieged-qusra-families · **Irish Times** irishtimes.com/world/middle-east/2026/08/14 · **CBC** cbc.ca/news/world/washington-netanyahu-west-bank-settler-siege

ITALY, ROME & THE VATICAN

Pope Leo Presides Over Assumption Mass at Castel Gandolfo

Pope Leo XIV has been at the papal residence in Castel Gandolfo since the evening of Aug. 12 and remains there through Aug. 18. Today, for the Solemnity of the Assumption of the Blessed Virgin Mary, he presides over a 10 a.m. Mass at the Pontifical Parish of St. Thomas of Villanova in Castel Gandolfo.

Vatican News vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-leo-to-return-to-castel-gandolfo-until-18-august.html

General Audience: Sunday Is "Foundation and Kernel" of the Liturgical Year

At his Aug. 12 general audience — moved inside St. Peter's Basilica because of Rome's heat — Pope Leo continued his catechesis series on Vatican II's constitution on the sacred liturgy, Sacrosanctum Concilium, with an installment on the liturgical year. He called Sunday "the foundation and kernel of the whole liturgical year" and

said: "I urge everyone to seek the best possible conditions so that even those who are unable to take time off work on Sundays may take part in holy Mass." He stated explicitly that attendance at Sunday Mass cannot be replaced by virtual participation.

WHY IT MATTERS

General audience catechesis is ordinary papal magisterium, not an exercise of infallibility, but it still shapes parish practice worldwide; this installment reads as a direct corrective to pandemic-era streaming habits many parishes never fully reversed.

OSV News osvnews.com/full-text-pope-leo-xivs-general-audience-given-august-12-2026 · **USCCB** usccb.org/news/2026/pope-leo-says-sunday-foundation-and-kernel-liturgical-year

France Trip Schedule Confirmed: Paris, Lourdes, Metz, Sept. 25-28

The Vatican published (Aug. 7) the official schedule for Pope Leo's apostolic journey to France. During the trip he will meet with survivors of clerical sexual abuse, as he did on his recent trip to Spain.

EWTN News ewtnnews.com/vatican/vatican-releases-schedule-for-pope-leo-s-september-trip-to-france

WORLD

Meloni's Coalition Splits Over Ukraine

In Italy, Giorgia Meloni faces open coalition strain over Ukraine policy. Her own Fratelli d'Italia and coalition partner Forza Italia back continued support for Kyiv and NATO, but League leader Matteo Salvini has taken an openly pro-Russia line opposing European rearmament, and retired Gen. Roberto Vannacci's new hard-right party, National Future, argues Ukraine should accept a Russia-dictated peace deal. Salvini has publicly told Zelensky to "sign a peace agreement as soon as possible."

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the same fracture visible across several European right-wing coalitions — between a governing nationalist right that still values the transatlantic security relationship and an insurgent further right treating Ukraine support as an elite project out of step with its base.

The Conversation theconversation.com/giorgia-melonis-government-is-still-supporting-ukraine-and-backing-nato

RESEARCH & LONG READS

Islamic Theology: Textual Criticism of the Quran

Marijn van Putten's "Textual Criticism of the Quran" (2024, still the reference point for current work) applies manuscript-based textual criticism — the discipline long used on the Bible — to early Quranic codices, mapping variant readings and pre-/post-Uthmanic recensions rather than accepting the traditional account of a single, immediately fixed text. A newer 2026 study, Karim Samji's "The Qur'an: A Form-Critical History," classifies Quranic discourse into form-critical categories to reconstruct compositional layers. Together they treat the Quran's textual history as a historical-critical problem like any other ancient text — precisely what traditional Islamic doctrine on the Quran's perfect, unaltered preservation denies is possible.

TIMELY BECAUSE

This scholarship sits directly behind the news: the current US-Israel-Iran war has put the Islamic world's internal religious and political fault lines back in the spotlight.

Leiden University scholarlypublications.universiteitleiden.nl/handle/1887/3761723

American Right: The Unitary Executive Theory

Developed by Reagan-era DOJ lawyers including John Roberts and Samuel Alito, and famously argued in dissent by Scalia in the 1988 case Morrison v. Olson (a 7-1 loss for him at the time), the unitary executive theory holds that the president has full, unreviewable control over the executive branch. Recent essays trace how a once-marginal dissenting position became mainstream conservative legal doctrine and is now being tested against Trump's actual practice of executive power.

TIMELY BECAUSE

It's the exact doctrine at stake in today's SCOTUS ballroom fight over whether Congress or the president controls federal property.

Cambridge Core Legal Planet cambridge.org/core/journals/perspectives-on-politics-legal-planet.org/2026/01/22/what-critics-of-the-unitary-executive-theory-missed